SHAUN GIBSON

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Solicitor (Scotland), admitted 2007 • UK citizen

EXECUTIVE PROFILE

Sports legal and business affairs professional with over 14 years in commercial sport, specialising in football: lead counsel on club, federation and player partnerships, negotiating directly with elite clubs, rights holders, agents, federations and players, and advising on deal structure, commercial strategy and business affairs across some of the highest-value partnerships in global sport, with further depth in motorsport, rugby, athletics and major multi-sport events.

Computer science graduate and hands-on advocate for legal technology and AI, using them to make legal teams faster, more accurate and more commercially effective.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

adidas AG | Herzogenaurach (Germany) / Amsterdam / Hong Kong

Global Legal Director — Sports Marketing and Business Affairs

2018 – Present

One of the lead counsel for adidas' global sports marketing portfolio, spanning football, motorsport, rugby, tennis and athletics; negotiating endorsement, licensing and royalty-bearing agreements, from high-volume routine contracts to industry-first, brand-critical partnerships valued at over EUR 1bn, under significant time pressure and public scrutiny.

- Principal drafter and lead negotiator across athlete endorsement, club and federation partnerships, licensing, and agency agreements, and a commercial risk decision-maker on key deals. Recent lead-counsel deals: Liverpool FC, Mercedes-AMG Petronas F1 Team, New Zealand Rugby and Boston Marathon.
- Football legal lead: club kit-supply, licensing and partnership agreements including Liverpool FC and Arsenal FC; player endorsement agreements with Jude Bellingham, David Beckham and Lionel Messi, negotiated directly with agents and image-rights vehicles.
- Motorsport: legal lead on adidas' entry into Formula 1, covering Mercedes-AMG Petronas F1 Team, Audi Revolut F1 Team and a further leading team; built licensing and partnership templates and rights packages from scratch for a new category. Concluded endorsement agreements with drivers George Russell, Kimi Antonelli, Fernando Alonso and Valtteri Bottas. Advised on ambush-marketing risk and activation guardrails around F1 events.
- Governance and regulatory: go-to adviser on international federation regulation; adidas' primary contact for World Athletics on the Athletic Shoe Regulations, working alongside the WFSGI; adviser on Olympic event rights, Rule 40 and ambush/activation guardrails; representing adidas in sports-body collaborations and international competition projects.
- Lead the legal workstream for multiple sports categories: currently line-managing two lawyers, and having developed several members of the ten-lawyer international team over time (allocation, review, standard-setting and development). Part of adidas' global legal centre of excellence – advising and guiding other adidas lawyers in respect of sports-marketing and commercial-rights advice.
- Lead the legal function's adoption of legal technology and AI: daily use of generative AI tools (Copilot, Claude, ChatGPT) across drafting, research and negotiation to raise speed and accuracy; a Smartsheet resourcing tool built and rolled out across the team; and end-to-end contract automation with a maintained template and playbook suite – now generating thousands of agreements a year and recovering thousands of lawyer hours.
- Trusted adviser to executive leadership (GMs and VPs) through formal memos and decision briefings; instruct and manage external counsel on disputes within scope and budget.

Global Senior Legal Counsel — Commercial & Licensing *2015 – 2018*

Structured and negotiated cross-border licensing and commercial agreements globally; advising on exclusivity mechanics, royalty economics and distribution models across both consumer product and rights licensing portfolios.

- Primary adviser on a strategic review of the global licensee portfolio, including restructuring of distribution and commercial models with EU competition law considerations.
- Hong Kong secondment (2016–2017): led Asia-Pacific brand protection and IP enforcement across China and Indonesia; trademark portfolio management, anti-counterfeiting strategy and cross-border enforcement.

Baku 2015 European Games Organising Committee | Baku, Azerbaijan

Senior Commercial Lawyer *2014 – 2015*

- Lead commercial counsel for the inaugural European Games. Delivered from a standing start in under 12 months. Negotiated the full commercial rights programme end-to-end: global sponsorship (Coca-Cola, Red Bull), broadcast and host-broadcaster agreements (BT Sport, beIN SPORTS and others), event hosting and venue arrangements, and merchandising and licensing, all under extreme time pressure, with no precedent and no playbook. Advised organising-committee leadership and the European Olympic Committees on high-value decisions covering brand protection, ticketing and accreditation terms.

Glasgow 2014 Commonwealth Games Organising Committee | Glasgow, Scotland

Commercial Lawyer (seconded from Harper Macleod LLP) *2012 – 2014*

- Part of a lean six-person legal team delivering the full commercial legal programme for a major international multi-sport event hosted in Scotland, on a constrained budget. Sole owner of the master licensing agreement; lead sponsorship counsel (with Lagardère) on a ~£50m rights portfolio; advised on the international federation and national governing body arrangements underpinning each sport's competition delivery. Delivered against a fixed event deadline in a high-accountability, publicly funded environment.

Tesco Bank plc | Edinburgh, UK

Commercial Lawyer *2011 – 2012*

- Commercial contracting across a broad portfolio of banking and financial services agreements in a UK FSA-regulated (now FCA) environment. Early exposure to the compliance frameworks and governance structures that define heavily regulated enterprise operations.

Dentons LLP (formerly Maclay Murray & Spens) | Edinburgh / Glasgow / London, UK

Solicitor & Trainee — IP & Technology *2007 – 2011*

- Contentious and non-contentious IP & Technology practice at a leading international firm: commercial IP and IT contracts, licensing, and IP enforcement including litigation and regulatory proceedings, with seats across Corporate Tax, Commercial Property and Construction & Engineering, and a secondment to Police Scotland on commercial matters.

EDUCATION & QUALIFICATIONS

BSc (Hons) Computer Science with Law — First Class 2005
University of Strathclyde, Glasgow

LLB Law (Graduate Entry) 2006
University of Strathclyde, Glasgow

Diploma in Legal Practice (Scotland) 2007
Glasgow Graduate School of Law

Solicitor (Scotland) — admitted to the roll 2007

Executive Legal Function programme 2022
Bucerius Law School, Hamburg